Chapter 2

Meena's Kite

Meena lives in a small town in Gujarat. Every year in January, people in Gujarat celebrate the festival of Makar Sankranti, which they call Uttarayan. On this day, almost everyone goes up to the rooftops to fly kites.

Weeks before the festival, Meena and her grandfather make kites together. Grandfather cuts thin sticks of bamboo and ties them in the shape of a cross. Meena pastes coloured paper over the frame. This year her favourite kite was bright yellow with a long red tail. She named it Sunny.

On the morning of the festival, the whole family went up to the roof. The sky was already full of kites of every colour - red, green, blue and orange. People were shouting "Kai po che!" whenever they cut another kite's string.

Meena held the string tightly while her brother Arjun held the kite up high. When the wind blew, Arjun let go, and Sunny rose into the sky. It climbed higher and higher until it looked like a tiny yellow bird.

Suddenly, another kite came close to Sunny. Its string rubbed against Meena's string, and snap! Meena's string was cut. Sunny floated away over the houses and landed on the roof of old Mrs. Desai, who lived alone at the end of the street.

Meena felt very sad. "I have lost Sunny," she said, with tears in her eyes. Grandfather smiled and said, "Let us go and ask Mrs. Desai for it."

Mrs. Desai opened the door with the yellow kite in her hands. She was smiling. "When I was a little girl, I flew kites just like this one," she said. Meena saw that Mrs. Desai looked a little lonely, so she asked, "Will you fly kites with us this evening?"

That evening, Mrs. Desai joined the family on the roof. She showed Meena how to hold the string so that it would not be cut easily. Everyone shared chikki made of sesame seeds and jaggery. When the sun set, Meena said, "I lost my kite for a little while, but I found a new friend."

Let's talk

1. What do people in Gujarat call Makar Sankranti?
2. How did Meena lose her kite?
3. Why did Meena invite Mrs. Desai to fly kites?

New words

frame - the sticks that give a kite its shape
jaggery - a brown sweet made from sugarcane juice